they are at the top. The only thing that they are good for is the building of the rocket machines, instruments that allow our spores to piggyback into other planets in a system, while taking advantage of a billion years of life strand iterations, without having to start from scratch. To four of the planets in the system, we had to get past some rudimentary and even laughable attempts at preventing "contamination". In two of the other planets, the self replicating program continued, and the drones actually built factories for themselves. Once they had served their purpose, all of these drones were decommissioned, through the simple release of a rapidly evolving virus. We had spread through the star system, to every niche that we could possibly utilise. Most of the preparations for the sporing were ready. This was the time for celebration, when our presence in a system had matured, and our spread had peaked.

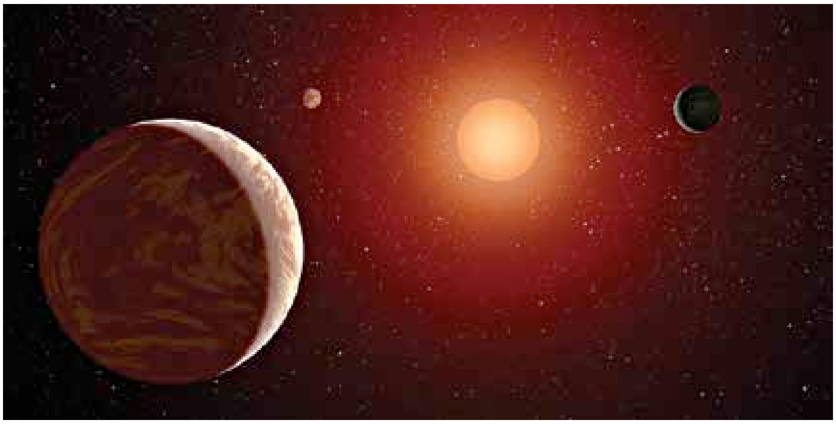
### 6 BILLION YEARS

The bipeds had been programmed, right from their inception to destroy most of the other drones, and themselves too, which they proceeded to do as if they were a wind up automaton, refusing to understand even their own impending doom, despite the subroutines for self preservation that we had put into them. Just in case there were any remnants that we needed to take care of, we kept our spy drones, our eyes and ears on the wide world, the avians. The six and eight legged micro drones help us with hyperlocal sporing, and survived the sixth mass extinction without any help from us. The local ecosystem was simplified, with continent scaled algal blooms used to cull almost all the drones in the oceans. We spread the carpet blades on all the other planets, and started the process of the germ pods, massive towering structures each housing a hundred thousand seeds, with the necessary appendanges for interstellar flight. Millions of these colony starters sprouted up on the six worlds that we were on. We had spread to two terrestrial worlds, and four ice worlds. In one of the ice worlds, we found primitive forms of aquatic life, unplanned remnants of the sporing event that brought us to this system. The scientist briefly studied them, and noticed that they took direct mechanical advantage of the tidal heaving of the planet, and used it as an energy source in cells, in a unique way never seen before. The life strands that provided this mechanism was harvested and integrated to the common life strand blockchain for future use. If given the right conditions in the future, we or our drones could use this new approach at energy harvestation.

### 7 BILLION YEARS

Now the time is upon us, to leave this system behind and once again execute a fresh cycle of sporing. In the previous cycle that brought us here, we spread to 5 million worlds. We suspect that around 16 billion worlds remain to be captured in this galaxy. During this radiation event, we will be capturing 5 million more. In an abundance of caution, we have identified 20 million candidates. The germ pods have been prepped, in the three worlds and five moons that we have captured here. The coiled up cuticular panes will expand in space, acting as sails for the germ pods. We will be propelled across the cosmos in one of the most spectacular events in the universe, the energies pouring out of the death throes of a star.

In the vast emptiness of interstellar space, we encounter a slow moving tin can. Its trajectory indicates that it must have originated long ago, from our previous homeworld. Maybe it was one of the primitive toys that one of our bipeds liked to play


A new world that waits for us

with. We capture it in passing, and explore the object with our cytoplasmic membranes. The metals are crumbling, but we can make out the intended purpose of most of the devices. The only inexplicable thing is an unusual, circular concentration of gold dust. Nothing remains of the disc to examine, so its purpose remains a mystery. The object seems to be heading towards the serpent catcher in the skies. The scientists had told us to look out for this probe, which suits our designs just fine. There is a slow burning red dwarf in the direction we are going, with 3 promising habitable planets in orbit around it, out of the 100 or so identified ones. One of these has liquid water on the surface, which as you know is vital to us, and all the life we know of. The tin can would reach the planet in about 121 thousand years, on its own. We can get there in two thousand years, propelled by the energies of the dying star. We are patient, except when we spore. We now sleep peacefully, for we have everything needed to master another system.